about fire engines and police vans rushing to Konanakunte. Anirudhya, too, had noticed a fire engine heading in the same direction as his taxi. They followed the speeding fire engine into a dusty, bumpy road and then to a poor locality with thatched-roof houses and many under-construction structures. The vast, barren spaces between the houses were punctuated with stray cattle, storage areas for paddy and heaps of cow dung. It didn't take long, though, for the scene to change dramatically the moment the taxi came close to the house under the scanner.

Policemen were everywhere—on rooftops and various strategic positions. Everyone's gaze was fixed on a light-yellow house stained with rainwater marks. Everyone present there, from cop to peanut seller to children playing in the streets, knew the mastermind of Rajiv Gandhi's assassination and his gang were holed up there.

Anirudhya quickly tore a blank page off his notepad, scribbled 'PRESS' on it and pasted it on the windscreen of the taxi. The cops did not stop his taxi, but when asked what was going on, didn't say anything wither, simply waving the car on. Anirudhya was wondering if his Bangalore bureau chief Saritha Rai would be there. She had filed her copies independently to Delhi even as the news desk of *India Today* kept updating its next big story. Nevertheless, for Anirudhya it was more important to find a contact or a source than a colleague.

Senior members of the SIT had started reaching Bangalore. It looked like the time for the grand finale had come. But the SIT's primary concern was the complete lack of cooperation from the local police. The question of catching Sivarasan alive had been discussed over and over again within the SIT. The chase was being led by the tracking team. However, they could not raid the hideouts or catch the assassins without the permission of the local police. The NSG's Black Cat commandos were an integral part of the tracking team. The situation at Konanakunte was ideal for their skill sets and expertise. The incident during the Indira Nagar operation, when the LTTE cadres had bitten their cyanide capsules, was enough to suggest that Sivarasan and gang would do the same.